replacing experts with loyalists, thereby obstructing data collection and undermining the flow of information to IOs (Carnegie, Clark, and Zucker 2024).

This tactic isn't limited to withholding information; populists actively weaponize communication to sow distrust in IOs. Anti-globalist rhetoric, fiery speeches, and campaigns blaming IOs for domestic problems erode public confidence in these institutions (Dellmuth and Tallberg 2023; Handlin, Kaya, and Günaydin 2023). By vilifying IOs as symbols of elitism and external meddling, populists cultivate domestic backlash and raise the political costs of cooperation with these organizations.

Importantly, populists do not always disengage completely from IOs. Sometimes they stay within such institutions but seek to repurpose them to advance domestic agendas. By reshaping an organization's mandate or exploiting procedural loopholes, populists redirect IO efforts to align with their priorities, weakening the institution's broader mission (Gray 2018; Spandler and Söderbaum 2023). Orbán has sought to do so with various EU immigration initiatives, for instance.

These tactics can sow toxic environments within IOs, fostering inefficiency, division, and the erosion of legitimacy. Whether through disengagement, noncompliance, or deliberate manipulation, populists hollow out institutions, reducing their capacity to serve as effective global governance actors. However, as the following section explores, IOs are not passive in this battle; they actively develop strategies to push back against populist resistance.

1.4 IOs as Strategic Agents

The central focus of our theory and empirical analysis is to uncover how IOs respond to populist attacks. While much is known about the array of tactics countries use to defend themselves against external threats, far less attention has been paid to the defensive toolkits possessed by IOs. What tools do these institutions wield in their efforts to counter hostility and maintain cooperation among their members? We argue that IOs' strategies diverge in important ways from those employed by states within institutions, reflecting their unique nature and constraints.